Monticello-UVA Archaeological Field School
Anthropology 5589: Summer 2026
Course Description

The Course

This course introduces the fundamentals of field techniques in historical archaeology, their methodological underpinnings, and the substantive issues in early Chesapeake social history that can be addressed through archaeological evidence. You will learn the basic excavation, sampling, and recording techniques required to successfully execute multidisciplinary field research. We will also explore the relationships among field techniques, the data they produce, and the archaeologist's ability to make and evaluate inferences about history.

Analytical approaches covered in the course include the use of ceramics in chronological inference, the analysis of faunal remains for dietary reconstruction, and the utility of geoarchaeological and dendrochronological methods in the reconstruction of land-use history. Additionally, we will examine how architecture and artifact spatial patterns are used to make inferences about the social use of space. While the social, economic, and ecological dynamics of early Chesapeake society provide our historical focus, on-site instruction at Monticello will be complemented by lectures, discussions, and field trips to related sites.

Historical Background

Two broad historical trends, one economic and the other demographic, set the stage for our research at Monticello and the Field School. By the second quarter of the eighteenth century, slavery-based plantations growing tobacco for export began to spread rapidly from the Coastal Plain into the Piedmont region where Monticello is located. For the remainder of the century, the Piedmont remained the most economically dynamic region of Virginia. As the eighteenth century drew to a close, plantation owners responded to shifting local and trans-Atlantic markets by diversifying their sources of income. These efforts included new agricultural crops, more intensive methods of cultivation, and even forays into manufacturing. Specifically, hoe-based tobacco monoculture was supplemented or replaced by a more diversified regime centered on the plow cultivation of wheat.

Fundamental demographic shifts paralleled these economic developments. The migration of enslaved people from older plantations in the Coastal Plain, direct importation from Africa, and natural increase all contributed to rapid growth in the region's enslaved population. By the end of the eighteenth century, this population was comprised almost entirely of native-born individuals.

Our research at Monticello aims to trace the conflicting strategies pursued by

plantation owners such as Thomas Jefferson and the enslaved people who lived there. We examine how both groups attempted to navigate these shifting circumstances to improve their own and their families' life chances in the Colonial and Antebellum Chesapeake.

We are guided by several core questions. How did the co-evolving economic and social strategies of elites and enslaved laborers shift as settlement moved into the Piedmont? How were these strategies affected by economic diversification near the end of the century, and what were the ecological and social consequences? Furthermore, how did enslaved people resist these systems or turn them to their own advantage? We also consider the specific opportunities and constraints that economic diversification and growing kinship networks offered enslaved people in their attempts to better their lives. Finally, our research focuses on how Jefferson and his family devised social strategies to facilitate interaction with other elites. Over the course of his lifetime, Jefferson's travels, reading, and correspondence expanded the scale of his social networks and the design vocabularies to which he was exposed. We ask how this influenced his use of architectural and ornamental landscape designs to signal social status. These signals had to be understood by increasingly diverse audiences, ranging from British colonial administrators before the Revolution to European aristocrats and nation-state officials after it.

Through this course, you will help answer these questions by drawing on our current archaeological research at Monticello as well as comparative data from across the Atlantic World. This program offers you the opportunity to be a part of the research process in both the field and the lab.

The Site

In 2026, our fieldwork focuses on stratigraphic excavations designed to advance our understanding of Thomas Jefferson's mansion and the ornamental landscape. We aim to explore how these designs were executed by enslaved workers and how the resulting environment shaped social interactions among Monticello's residents, including both enslaved and free individuals, as well as visiting elites.

Our team will excavate five-foot quadrats on and adjacent to the West Lawn and North Yard. Previous research indicates that the current topography, which includes the level West Lawn and its surrounding slopes, is essentially a massive artifact. This landscape was constructed by enslaved workers during two major earth-moving episodes in the 1770s and 1790s. Through this work, we hope to gain deeper insight into the spatial design and the immense labor required to realize it.

The North Yard, situated adjacent to the mansion's north wing, is also a primary focus. Previous fieldwork and ongoing assemblage analysis suggest this area served as a major disposal site for items used and broken by the Jefferson family and their guests, particularly those from the dining room. We intend to test this hypothesis and subsequently compare these findings with domestic assemblages from the households of enslaved individuals living on Mulberry Row.

Reading

Reading, updated copies of the Syllabus, and Course Description will be found on GitHub:

https://github.com/TJF-Monticello/Monticello-UVA-Archaeological-Field-School-2026

In addition, you will receive printed copies of the Monticello Department of Archaeology's *Lab Procedures Manual* and *Field Procedures Manual*. ***We expect you to come to class having done the reading assigned for that day.***

Daily Schedule

Our class day begins at 8:30 a.m. and ends at 4:30 p.m. We'll assemble at 8:30 at the Monticello Visitor's Center. Most lectures will take start at 8:30 at the VC in Classroom 7. We will then take the shuttle bus up to the site. On days when there is no morning lecture, you should be at the shuttle stop at 8:30. There is a thirty-minute break at noon for lunch at the site. You are responsible for packing your own lunch.

Once we begin to recover artifacts from our excavations, we will rotate excavation teams through the lab, where you will learn the basics of artifact processing -- washing, labeling, curation, and keeping track of critical archaeological context information for each object. You'll learn about the classification and measurement protocols and software we use to catalog artifacts and field records into our database (see www.daacs.org). You'll have a chance to hone your artifact identification skills with the artifacts you are processing, as well as examples from our extensive study collection.

Field School Staff

Fraser D. Neiman	Director	fneiman@monticello.org
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DAACS Lab

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Chiara Torrini	Archeological Analyst	ctorrini@monticello.org
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Guest Lecturers

Auriana Woods	Oral Historian, *Getting Word* Oral History Project, Monticello (slavery at Monticello, oral history, descendant engagement).
Justin Bates	Manager of Special Programs, Monticello (slavery at Monticello, public interpretation).
Dan Druckenbrod	Professor, Geography and Environmental Science, Rider University (dendrochronology and dendroecology).
Dan Hayes	Geoarchaeologist (geoarchaeology).
Kandace Hollenbach	Professor, Department of Anthropology, University of Tennessee (paleoethnobotany).

Requirements and Evaluation

Class Participation. We expect you to attend all field sessions, lectures, and discussions. Readings are to be completed before coming to the session at which they are scheduled to be discussed. You should try to digest and evaluate what you have read and be prepared to share your understanding of the reading and any questions you have about it in class.

Quality Field and Lab Work. You are responsible for learning completely and executing accurately our recording and artifact processing protocols, as described in the *Field Procedures Manual* and *Laboratory Procedures Manual.* You will be creating archival field and lab records. We expect you to do high-quality of your field and lab work. This includes correctly identifying and efficiently excavating layers, completely recovering artifacts from them, and generating accurate and legible context records, plan, and section drawings. It also includes efficiently and effectively cleaning, drying, labeling, and identifying artifacts, ensuring accurate preservation of information on their excavation contexts.

Given the destructive character of archaeological excavation, the observations you make can never be repeated and the records you create are the only records there will ever be. We therefore take our obligations for completeness, accuracy, and standardization in excavation and recording very seriously. We expect you to do the same. Study the field and lab manuals carefully.

You will meet regularly with our teaching staff to review your field and lab skills. These aspects of your performance will determine 40% of your grade.

Quizzes. Two quizzes, one at the end of the second week and one at the end of the fourth week will give you some intermediate feedback on your progress and determine 30% of your grade.

Final Exam. The results of a 2-hour written examination, covering lectures, readings, and both field and lab skills will determine 30% of your grade.